

Guide to Classical Composers

Part 1: The Baroque Era (1600-1750)

Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750) was the greatest composer of the Baroque period. His Brandenburg Concertos, six orchestral works dedicated to Christian Ludwig of Brandenburg, remain among the most important orchestral compositions ever written. His Well-Tempered Clavier demonstrated that keyboard instruments could be tuned to play in all 24 major and minor keys.

Antonio Vivaldi (1678-1741) was an Italian Baroque composer known for his concertos, especially The Four Seasons. He composed over 500 concertos and helped establish the three-movement concerto form.

Part 2: The Classical Period (1750-1820)

Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart (1756-1791) was a child prodigy who became one of the most prolific composers in Western music history. His operas including The Marriage of Figaro, Don Giovanni, and The Magic Flute revolutionized opera. He composed 41 symphonies, 27 piano concertos, and numerous chamber works.

Ludwig van Beethoven (1770-1827) bridged the Classical and Romantic periods. His Symphony No. 9 in D minor incorporated a choir for the first time in a major symphony, setting Friedrich Schiller poem Ode to Joy to music. He continued composing masterworks even after becoming completely deaf.

Part 3: Musical Instruments in the Orchestra

The piano, invented by Bartolomeo Cristofori around 1700, has 88 keys spanning over 7 octaves. It produces sound by hammers striking strings when keys are pressed. The sustain pedal allows notes to ring after the key is released.

The violin is the soprano voice of the string family. It has four strings tuned to G3, D4, A4, and E5. The violin section is the largest section in a symphony orchestra, typically with 16 first violins and 14 second violins.

The trumpet is the highest-pitched brass instrument in the orchestra. Modern trumpets have three valves that allow the player to access a complete chromatic scale. Famous trumpet concertos include those by Haydn and Hummel.

Part 4: Music Theory Essentials

The major scale follows the interval pattern: whole step, whole step, half step, whole step, whole step, whole step, half step. This pattern starting from C gives the C major scale: C D E F G A B C.

Harmony is the simultaneous sounding of two or more notes. A chord is a group of three or more notes played together. The most basic chord is the triad, built by stacking thirds.